



THE OPERATOR SERIES · OCTOBER 2026

The Lead Vendor Vetting Checklist

Know what you're buying. Test it fairly. Follow the math to placed policies.

A lead price tells you what you paid for a record. This guide helps you decide whether that record can work with your offer, your agents, and your follow-up system.

Insurance agents

Agency owners

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Ask ten questions. Request evidence.
Record the answers. Resolve unknowns.
Run a bounded trial. Track what matters.

Includes an evidence worksheet and a vendor trial scorecard.





QUESTIONS 01-02 · PRODUCT AND PERMISSION

Start with the consumer's request.

QUESTION 01

What, exactly, am I buying?

Ask: “Define the product in writing: age, sharing, geography, insurance interest, and source.”

Look for: Definitions of fresh, aged, exclusive, and shared; number of buyers and resale rules; what exclusivity covers and for how long; whether the vendor generates inquiries or buys from partners.

Read the answer: Fresh, aged, shared, and partner-sourced products can serve different jobs. Evaluate the disclosed product and price against how your team will work it. The label must mean the same thing to both parties.

Follow-up: Which details can I verify on the records I receive?

QUESTION 02

What did the person request?

Ask: “Show me the experience that created the inquiry and the contact-permission evidence retained.”

Look for: A redacted example of the ad, page, form, offer, and permission wording; the request and timestamps; the channels and recipient categories described; how those records can be retrieved.

Read the answer: An insurance quote request and an incentive-driven form fill create different conversations. Review the actual request and permission evidence with the person responsible for your contact rules.

Follow-up: Can you show a redacted example from this exact product?



QUESTIONS 03–04 · RECORDS AND HANDOFF

Know what arrives—and where it goes.

QUESTION 03

Can I inspect a complete sample?

Ask: “Show me a redacted record and walk me through its fields and timestamps.”

Look for: Product, geography, source IDs, inquiry time, and delivery time; partner acquisition time where relevant; age and known distribution history for aged inventory; a link to permission evidence.

Read the answer: Measure fresh lead age from the consumer’s inquiry to your delivery. A sample shows the format; the trial shows whether live records consistently match it. Mark unknown history as unknown.

Follow-up: Which fields are consistently present, and which may be missing?

QUESTION 04

How do routing and duplicates work?

Ask: “What happens between the order and an agent owning the lead?”

Look for: Delivery and field mapping; volume, pause, and overflow rules; failure alerts; duplicate definition and lookback window; checks against your CRM, including other vendors’ records.

Read the answer: Separate vendor delivery from internal assignment. “No duplicates” needs a scope: this order, the vendor’s inventory, or your existing records. Each delivered lead needs an available owner.

Follow-up: Can we safely verify delivery and its failure alert before the paid trial?



QUESTIONS 05–06 · FIT AND REMEDIES

Agree on what “good” means.

QUESTION 05

Does this product fit our business?

Ask: “Who is the product designed for, and what did those people expect?”

Look for: Insurance interest, geography, language, and available qualifying information; the attracting offer; screening performed; the screening your team is expected to do.

Read the answer: Match the product to your service area, product lines, agent capacity, and actual process. A product another agency works well can still be a poor fit for your team.

Follow-up: What would make my agency a poor fit for this product?

QUESTION 06

What happens when a record is invalid?

Ask: “Show me the acceptance and remedy policy before I order.”

Look for: Definitions for invalid contacts, duplicates, wrong geography or product, and missing required data; claim deadlines and evidence; resolution time; replacement, credit, or refund terms and credit expiry.

Read the answer: A disconnected number, a valid person who did not answer, and someone who chose not to buy are different events. Keep record-quality disputes separate from sales outcomes and apply agreed definitions.

Follow-up: Walk me through a claim from submission to resolution.



QUESTIONS 07-08 · EVIDENCE AND OWNERSHIP

Demand a useful denominator.

QUESTION 07

Which outcomes can you substantiate?

Ask: “When you say these leads perform, what result are you counting?”

Look for: Cohort dates, lead counts, spend, and rate denominators; definitions of contact, appointment, written and placed policy; maturity window; source attribution and the agent process behind the result.

Read the answer: Sales screenshots need context. Some vendors cannot see buyers’ policy outcomes. Evaluate what they can demonstrate, then agree on what you will track in your own trial.

Follow-up: Can we reconcile delivery, CRM, and policy records by source?

QUESTION 08

Who owns a problem?

Ask: “If delivery stops or records do not match the order, what happens next?”

Look for: Support channel, responsible owner or team, coverage hours, response expectations, escalation process, and issue tracking; clear responsibility for delivery versus your CRM and routing.

Read the answer: A direct contact and a ticket queue can both work. Judge support by clear ownership, visible progress, and reliable resolution. Confirm the process before an urgent issue arrives.

Follow-up: What information helps you diagnose a failed delivery quickly?



QUESTIONS 09–10 · TERMS AND TRIAL

Make the commitment measurable.

QUESTION 09

What is the full cost—and how do we stop?

Ask: “Show me the costs and exit conditions for the trial and ongoing orders.”

Look for: Lead price, setup and platform fees, minimums, billing and renewal rules, notice periods, pauses; handling of prepaid balances and disputes; what you can export and retain when you leave.

Read the answer: Compare the whole commitment. A longer agreement may have a commercial reason; understand the reason and conditions before signing. Know what happens when the trial ends.

Follow-up: What happens if I place no further order after the trial?

QUESTION 10

Can we run a fair, measurable trial?

Ask: “What evidence will help us continue, adjust, or stop?”

Look for: Comparable cases or permitted references and how those buyers were selected; budget and volume limits; delivery and review dates, follow-up process, decision criteria, and data owners.

Read the answer: A reference provides context. Your trial establishes fit. Log lead age, agent assignment, response timing, and follow-up. Allow placement results to mature before deciding.

Follow-up: Which result would make each of us recommend stopping?



WORKING PAGE · EVIDENCE

Put the answers on one page.

Vendor / product:

Reviewer / date:

Lead age / sharing / source:

Insurance interest / geography:

0 = unclear or unanswered · 1 = stated, awaiting evidence · 2 = documented and checkable.
The score tracks evidence completeness. Product fit and trial economics determine the decision.

Question	0–2	Evidence / follow-up needed
01 · Product definition		
02 · Request + permission		
03 · Records + age		
04 · Routing + duplicates		
05 · Product fit		
06 · Invalids + remedies		
07 · Outcome evidence		
08 · Support + ownership		
09 · Cost + exit terms		
10 · Trial plan		

Resolve these before the paid trial

- ☐ Product, age, sharing, and source are clear.
- ☐ Request and permission evidence reviewed; product fits our capacity.
- ☐ Costs, invalid criteria, remedies, and exit terms agreed.
- ☐ Delivery works; agents own records; measurement is ready.

Decision: ☐ Defined trial ☐ Clarify first ☐ Pass

Unresolved question / next action / owner / due date:



WORKING PAGE · TRIAL

Measure a fair trial.

Vendor / product / budget:

Volume limit / follow-up owner:

Delivery dates / outcome review date:

Continue / adjust / stop criteria:

Track unique leads at each stage; count total policies separately. Define “placed” against your policy records. Compare similar product, age, sharing, capacity, and follow-up conditions.

Trial measure	Count / value
Vendor spend, including order fees	\$
Delivered / accepted leads	/
Unique leads attempted / reached	/
Unique leads booked / attended	/
Unique leads with written / placed policy	/
Total policies placed	
Invalids disputed / remedied	/
Delivery-to-first-attempt timing	
Outcomes as of / maturity status	

Read the funnel

Reach rate: unique leads reached ÷ accepted leads.

Show rate: attended ÷ booked.

Placement rate: unique leads with a placed policy ÷ accepted leads.

Read the acquisition cost

Vendor cost per placed policy: vendor spend ÷ total policies placed.

Add labor and platform costs separately when assessing total acquisition economics.

For zero denominators, mark “no result yet.” Use “N/A” without appointments. Immature outcomes stay pending.

First leak / next change / owner:



WORK WITH JEROMY

Bring the answers. Bring the numbers.

Use the checklist to understand the product. Use the trial scorecard to understand your system. I can help you connect the two.

FREE FUNNEL TEARDOWN · 30 MINUTES

Bring your numbers. Leave with a first move.

- Your leak stage.
- What the math looks like fixed.
- The one change I'd make first.
- The recording and notes—yours whether we work together or not.

Get your Free Funnel Teardown →

jeromykovatana.com/contact#book

If the teardown isn't useful in the first 10 minutes, we call it there. No pitch.

Two ways to work together

GOAT Leads: the platform, systems, and lead engine. **Work with me directly:** acquisition and operating systems inside your business. Scope follows your bottleneck, economics, and capacity.

Bring what you have

A recent lead cohort, spend, contact and placed-policy counts, retained commissions, and a look at your routing and follow-up. If something is unknown, mark it unknown. That is useful information too.

Explore my work: jeromykovatana.com · Booking alternative: cal.com/jeromyk/funnel-teardown

The operator's perspective

My background spans audit at Ernst & Young and Grant Thornton, then a CFO role. As CTO of GOAT Leads and founder of LeadsBakery, I connect acquisition, operations, and the math from a paid record to a placed policy.

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